together, these six propositions constitute a useful foundation to explain why the BRICS have hung together—at least so far.

THE VIEW FROM BEIJING: IN SEARCH OF LEGITIMACY AND UNTHREATENING LEADERSHIP

Of the BRICS members, China represents by far the largest economy, with the fastest growth in the last few decades; it also possesses the strongest global political influence. Since the global financial crisis in 2008, the United States and China have stood as the *de facto* G2 leading powers, as they engage global economic governance now under the auspices of the G20.[8] Since Xi Jinping's rise to the presidency of China in late 2012, the U.S.-China dialogue has operated under what China calls a "new type of great power relations."[9] In addition, China has a seat at every global and regional governance table, including a permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council (UNSC). With its massive foreign exchange reserves, budding international currency, and military and productive prowess backing the economy, China can go it alone all the way, if it wishes, to implement financial statecraft to defend itself or to shape global economic debate and governance. Furthermore, China now has the financial power to entice and coerce others to its advantage. Nevertheless, it has been unequivocally supportive of the BRICS' process,[10] and it has even taken multiple actions to promote cooperation among the members, as discussed later in this chapter. As the other BRICS members struggle with China's exports overwhelming their markets, China has also been willing to provide access to its currency, the renminbi (RMB), for trade settlement through currency swap agreements, and has showed its willingness to compromise on the structure of the BRICS New Development Bank (NDB).

China's willingness to collaborate with BRICS members is even more curious considering that the group includes two of China's traditional archrivals, Russia and India. Despite gradual and visible improvement in the bilateral relationship between China and both countries since the early 1990s, rivalry and tension occasionally flare up, particularly with India. China is one of the countries that has benefited immensely by the existing liberal economic order. Now more than ten times the size it was when it reengaged the Bretton Woods institutions, China can challenge global governance structures by itself if its leadership so chooses, as stated